

Washing

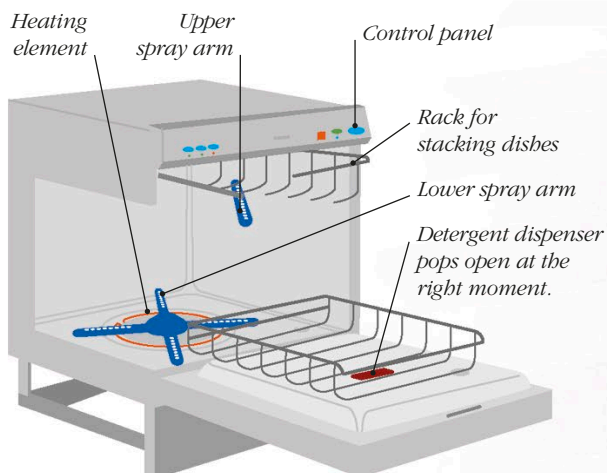
The world's first mechanical dishwasher was created by the wealthy American Josephine Cochrane in the 19th century, supposedly to prevent her servants from breaking her plates. Upon discovering there wasn't already such a machine, she apparently said, "If nobody else is going to invent a dish-washing machine, I'll do it myself." Unveiled in 1893, it was soon followed by many other domestic washing devices.



Dishwasher connected to hot-water tap, 1921

MODERN DISHWASHERS

Unlike in Cochrane's invention, the dishes in modern dishwashers are stacked in racks that don't move. Mechanical arms at the top and bottom spin around, squirting water over the dishes—first a cold prewash; then hot, soapy water; followed by clean, rinsing water. Finally, a heating element heats the air to dry the dishes.



THE FIRST DISHWASHER

Cochrane's dishwasher held the dishes in a wire rack that was turned by hand using a lever. As the dishes turned, they were squirted first with hot, soapy water and then with cold, clean water. The result was sparkling, clean dishes. However, her machine was big and bulky. Small domestic dishwashers wouldn't become popular until the 1950s.

Inside the tub was a motorized arm to spin the clothes around.

FRESH LAUNDRY

In the 19th century, some businesses had begun operating laundries with large, steam-powered washing machines. But it wasn't until 1908 that the American inventor Alva Fisher came up with the first commercially successful electric washing machine, the Thor. It had a cylinder that rotated, containing the water for the wash. Although the design was fairly basic and the clothes had to have the water squeezed out by hand, it sold well, and spurred many imitators. Later models of Thor (right) had rollers for squeezing excess water from clothes.

Water from the wet clothes drained back into the tub.

